The power of such planetary conjunctions, as indicators of future fortune and misfortune, is also central to the great Sanskrit epics of ancient India. In the *Ramayana*, when Ravana is getting the better of Rama in battle, the planets are blamed: 'Mercury stood covering the Rohini nakshastra which is presided over by Prajapati and which is the favourite of the moon and thereby indicated evil fortune to people.'[49] The *Mahabharata* is crowded with similar prophecies. An instance is the vivid description of future destruction in the Bhishma-parva, the forthcoming apocalypse being read from astrological indications: here a white celestial body stood 'traversing Citra nakshatra', indicating the destruction of the clan of the Kurus, while when 'a very frightful comet stands covering Pushya-nakshastra' it meant that terrible evil would visit both the armies in conflict.[50] Such examples suppose that knowledge about the future, even though usually hidden, can be secured by understanding specific signs. The phenomenon of prediction and divination, in fact, is part of all kinds of ancient literature and one only has to think of Joseph in the Old Testament using a cup for divination, or of the Chinese work *I Ching*, the Confucian classic on divination, to realize that this phenomenon was not confined to India.[51] Much later, West Asia's Qu'ranic stories about Biblical prophets allude to such practices, as when the Qu'ran recounts that the signal for the commencement of the Flood, for Noah, was a boiling furnace.[52]

The devices used for foretelling events in the world of ancient societies, one imagines, were those that were culturally acceptable there. In the ancient world of the Greek epics it was usual for the poet to leave the role of prophecy to his characters. So, in the fifteenth book of the *Iliad*, it was Zeus in conversation with Hera who prophesied various deaths when 'Achilles shall send Patroclus into battle, but that when Patroclus has slain many Trojan youths and Zeus' own son, Sarpedon, Hector in turn shall kill him; then Achilles in anger shall slay Hector and later the Achaeans with Athene's aid shall take the city of Ilium.'[53] This also underlines the fact that